

Supporting role

When referring to prices, we've given the price for a boxed retail copy of Windows Vista. This is because most versions of Vista are available in two types: boxed retail copies and Original Equipment Manufacturer (OEM) copies. When you buy a computer with Windows installed you'll get the OEM version, but if choosing a copy of Vista yourself, either for a new PC or an upgrade, it's worth knowing the difference.

Retail boxed copies of Vista are designed to be sold to computer owners. They're more expensive but they include a manual and, more importantly, support. Microsoft includes 90 days of technical support, via phone or email, from the day you activate a retail copy of Vista, so if you hit problems it should be able to help — unless your problem involves connecting to a network, which is an 'advanced' support issue and not covered.

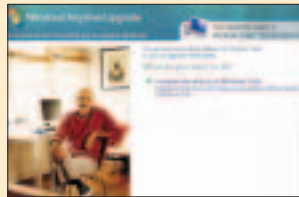
OEM copies of Vista are designed for people who make or sell computers. They're cheaper, but don't include a manual or any support from Microsoft. Instead, the company that installs the copy of Vista (in most cases the PC manufacturer) pledges to provide support for it themselves. This means that if you bought a

Hidden upgrade

Unlike Windows XP, it is fairly easy to move between versions of Windows Vista. If you have a copy of Home Basic, for example, you can upgrade to Home Premium or Ultimate using a tool called Windows Anytime Upgrade — go to the Start menu and type anytime in the Search box to find it.

Anytime upgrade allows you to order an upgrade online, and Microsoft will send you a disc in the post. The prices aren't particularly keen, though: moving from Home Basic to Home Premium costs over approximately Rs. 3 500, even though the difference in online price between the two boxed versions is closer to approximately Rs. 1500.

Anytime Upgrade is worth considering if you bought a computer with Vista pre-installed and want a better version, but otherwise we'd strongly recommend checking out the features you want and picking the right version first time — you stand to save money by doing so.



Upgrade Vista online

computer with Vista you should contact the people you bought your computer from, not Microsoft, for any help. If you buy an OEM version and install it yourself you won't get any free support from anyone. At just approximately Rs. 5000 for a copy of Home Premium OEM, this may be a sacrifice worth making.

Should you require help from Microsoft, either for an OEM copy or after your 90 days of support are up, it can be purchased for approximately Rs. 3000 per incident. With this in mind, if you think you may need help when installing Vista, it may be worth paying more for a retail boxed copy.

Bits and bytes

Finally, most versions of Vista are available in two further types: 32-bit and 64-bit. These types refer to the way that the computer accesses its memory: older PCs were all 32-bit, but some modern ones can work in 64-bit mode. Generally speaking, it's still best to install the 32-bit version on home computers, as this is compatible with more peripherals.

The advantage of 64-bit Vista is that it can use more memory: most versions of 32-bit Vista are limited to 4GB of memory, but if you want more, the 64-bit versions can use more than twice as much — if you can afford it.

Whichever version of Vista you choose — unless, of course, you somehow acquire a copy of Vista Starter — you'll find that it contains useful hidden features that can make your computing life easier. Read on to find out more, and how to get the most from them.